



LEFT In a natural setting

In their native hot, dry climates, cacti and other succulents can achieve spectacular dimensions. Even in cooler temperate gardens, they can still make a bold impression but must be brought in for the winter, and repositioned outside again each summer.

observe their natural growing seasons by feeding and watering them more frequently when they're in growth and less so, if at all, when they are dormant.

Heated conservatories and greenhouses provide the best indoor habitat for most tender plants, although many also thrive in houses. The care they require depends on the plant, but as a guide, position sun-loving plants nearer the windows, shade-lovers farther away, and maintain high humidity levels by standing your plants on trays of moist gravel and misting them regularly. Some plants, such as moth orchids (*Phalaenopsis*), require good light but not direct sunlight. This can be achieved by positioning them on a north-facing window, or on a shelf close to a bright window. Also watch out for pests, which can flourish in the favorable conditions you provide.

Finding areas that provide optimal growing conditions for houseplants indoors can be difficult, so it is worth making best use of them where they occur. A good approach is to plant "community planters" and grow plants that enjoy similar conditions together in a single container. This is ideal for sun-loving cacti, as well as epiphytic orchids and bromeliads that need high humidity and insectivorous plants that prefer very moist soil.

When choosing and positioning tender plants indoors, consider the conditions they require. Light levels may be poor, even near windows, and air-conditioning and central heating can create a dry atmosphere, which many plants dislike. Another consideration is how large the plants will become; many exotic plants commonly grown as houseplants, such as the Swiss-cheese plant (*Monstera deliciosa*), and *Bougainvillea*, occupy considerable space over time, although they can be pruned and trained.

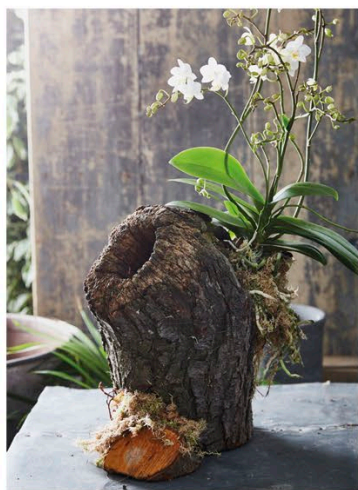
Caring for tender plants

All tender and exotic plants, like any other garden plant, have their preferred growing conditions, so consider your site, soil, and aspect carefully when planting outdoors. This is even more important when growing them indoors, as the plants are reliant on you for their care. The best approach is to try and mirror their natural conditions as closely as possible, providing the same degree of heat, light, shade, humidity, and ventilation. It is also very important to

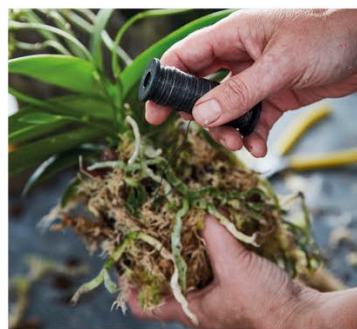
MAKING AN ORCHID DISPLAY

Orchids, such as *Phalaenopsis* *Allegria* gx, require particular conditions to perform at their best. Where you have a suitable spot indoors, take full advantage of it and create an attractive orchid display. Mounting an orchid

on decorative wood can be beneficial to your orchid's health. It mimics how the orchid would grow naturally and allows for good ventilation to the roots and good drainage, which will help your plant thrive and prevent disease.



The completed display



1 Remove the orchid from its pot and tease the potting medium from its roots. Pack sphagnum moss evenly in and around the roots, leaving some outer roots partially exposed. Gently secure in place with a little wire.



2 Position the orchid on the wood with the plant's crown angled downward. Wrap wire around the base and roots of the orchid to secure it to the wood (but not too tightly). When the plant is secure, twist the ends of the wire together and cut away the excess.



3 Decorate the rest of the piece of wood with additional handfuls of moss, secured with wire. Place in a humid area and mist daily. When in full growth, water 3 times a week by submerging the entire mount in a deep bowl for 20 minutes until saturated.